Himaayah Schools
SKILLS SCHOOL

GUIDE

أَوْفُوا بِالْعُقُودِ

"Fulfil your contracts." (al-Māʾidah 5:1)

Freelancing First Steps

Choose a skill, build a portfolio, find clients, set prices, get paid safely and trade honestly.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Freelancing means selling your skills to clients job by job, instead of working for one employer. With a phone or laptop and the internet, a young person in Nigeria can design, write, edit, translate, teach or manage social media for clients in their own city or across the world.

It is not “quick money”. It takes a real skill, patience and good character. This guide explains how to choose a skill, build a portfolio, find your first clients, set prices, write proposals, deliver work, get paid safely and avoid scams, with the Islamic principles of honest trade throughout. It ends with a 30-day plan.

> يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا أَوْفُوا بِالْعُقُودِ
>
> **“O you who believe, fulfil your contracts.”**
>
> Al-Mā’idah 5:1.

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Part 1 Is freelancing for you?

The good	The hard parts
You choose your clients and hours	Income can be irregular, especially at the start
You can work from home or anywhere with internet	You must find clients yourself
You can serve clients worldwide	Competition is high; quality and reliability matter
You grow a business and many skills	You manage deadlines, money and records yourself

Students

If you are still in school, keep your studies and prayers first. Start with small, local jobs at weekends and holidays, with your parents' knowledge.

Part 2 Choose a skill

Skill	Typical jobs	Where to start learning
Graphic design	Flyers, logos, social posts	Canva, then Figma or Adobe tools (see our guide **Design with Canva**)
Writing and editing	Articles, product descriptions, proofreading	Read widely; practise daily; free writing courses
Social media management	Planning and posting for businesses	Run a page for a real small business
Video editing	Reels, YouTube, event videos	CapCut on a phone, then DaVinci Resolve
Data entry and spreadsheets	Cleaning data, simple reports	Excel or Google Sheets (see our guide **Digital Skills for Beginners**)
Web and app development	Websites for small businesses	freeCodeCamp, The Odin Project
Tutoring	Qur'an, Arabic, school subjects	Teach what you know well; get a reference from your teacher

Choose **one** skill and get good at it before adding another. A skill you enjoy and practise every day will beat five skills you only know a little.

Part 3 Build a portfolio

- Make **5 to 10 samples** of your best work. If you have no clients yet, create sample projects for imaginary or local businesses.
- Show **before and after**, and explain the problem you solved.
- Put it in one easy link: a Behance, Instagram or GitHub page, a Google Drive folder, or a simple website.
- Collect **testimonials**: a sentence from each happy client, with their permission.
- Update it often; remove weak pieces as you improve.

Part 4 Find your first clients

1. **Start with people you know**: family businesses, neighbours, your school, masjid and community groups. Tell them clearly what you offer.
2. **Use WhatsApp Status and social media** to show your work regularly.
3. **Reach out to small businesses** with a short, polite message and one sample made for them.
4. **Join freelance platforms** when you have a portfolio (for example Upwork, Fiverr or Contra). Read each platform's rules, age limits and fees carefully; many require you to be 18 or older.

5 **Do excellent work and ask for referrals**: most freelancers get their best clients from happy clients.

A short outreach message

Assalāmu ʿalaykum, Mrs Adeyemi. I'm Yusuf, a graphic designer in Ilorin. I noticed your bakery posts on Instagram and made a sample post for your new cake range (attached). I'd be happy to design your posts each week. Would you like to see a few more samples?

Part 5 Set your prices

- **Research** what others with similar skill charge, locally and online.
- **Price per project** rather than per hour when you start: "₦10,000 for a flyer, with 2 revisions."
- **Count your costs**: data, electricity, software and time.
- **Start fair, then raise prices** as your portfolio and testimonials grow.
- **Say clearly what is included**: number of revisions, file types and delivery time.

Part 6 Proposals, contracts and delivery

Stage	What to do
Understand the brief	Ask questions: purpose, audience, sizes, deadline, examples they like.
Proposal	Restate the client's need, explain your plan, give price, timeline and what is included.
Agreement	Put it in writing, even in a WhatsApp message or email: work, price, deposit, revisions, deadline. This is your ʿaqd (contract).
Work	Share progress early; do not disappear.
Delivery	Deliver on time, in the right formats, and check the client is happy.
After	Ask for a testimonial and keep in touch for future work.

> وَأَوْفُوا الْكَيْلَ وَالْمِيزَانَ بِالْقِسْطِ
>
> **"And give full measure and weight in justice."**
>
> Al-Anʿām 6:152.

Part 7 Getting paid safely, and scams to avoid

- For new clients, ask for a **deposit** (for example 50%) before starting, and the rest before sending final files.

- Use bank transfers, trusted payment apps, or the platform's own payment system; never move off a platform to avoid its rules.
- Keep a simple **record** of every job, payment and expense.
- When your income reaches zakāh thresholds, include your savings in your zakāh (see our guide **The Fiqh of Zakāh**).

Scam	Warning sign
"Pay to get the job"	A real client never asks you to pay a fee to start work.
Fake overpayment	They "accidentally" send too much and ask for a refund before the payment clears.
Unpaid "test work"	They ask for a large free sample, then disappear with it.
Requests for personal details	They ask for your BVN, passwords or card details.
Work that is ḥarām or illegal	Writing fake reviews, doing students' exams, or promoting betting.

Part 8 Honest trade in Islām

"The truthful, trustworthy merchant is with the prophets, the truthful and the martyrs" (at-Tirmidhī, 1209). Freelancing is trade in your skill, so the rules of honest trade apply:

- **Be truthful** about your skill; take only work you can do.
- **Keep your word** on price and deadline; if there is a problem, tell the client early.
- **Do not cheat**: no copied work, and no hidden faults. "Whoever cheats is not of us" (Muslim, 102).
- **Pay what you owe** to anyone who helps you, quickly: "Give the worker his wage before his sweat dries" (Ibn Mājah, 2443).
- **Do not take work that helps ḥarām.**

Plan Your 30-day plan

Week	Action	Done
1	Choose one skill. Study and practise it every day for at least one hour.	☐
2	Make 5 portfolio samples and put them in one link.	☐
3	Send 10 polite outreach messages to people and small businesses you know.	☐
4	Complete your first paid job, ask for a testimonial, and record your income.	☐

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **Freelancing means:**

   a) Working for free b) Selling your skills to clients job by job c) Betting online d) Working for one boss only

2. **Before starting a new client's job, it is wise to:**

   a) Agree in writing and take a deposit b) Start without discussing price c) Pay the client d) Send your passwords

3. **A client asks you to pay a fee before you can start work. This is:**

   a) Normal b) A likely scam c) A deposit d) Zakāh

4. **"O you who believe, fulfil your contracts" is in:**

   a) Al-Māʾidah 5:1 b) Al-Fātiḥah 1:1 c) Yā Sīn 36:1 d) Al-Mulk 67:1

5. **The best first clients are often:**

   a) Strangers abroad only b) People and businesses you know c) No one d) Scammers

6. **Which job should a Muslim freelancer refuse?**

   a) A masjid flyer b) Writing fake reviews c) A school poster d) Proofreading

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Selling your skills job by job	4	a) Al-Māʾidah 5:1
2	a) Agree in writing, take a deposit	5	b) People and businesses you know
3	b) A likely scam	6	b) Writing fake reviews

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Sell your skill, keep your word.

This guide from the Himaayah Skills School shows young people how to start freelancing the right way, with the principles of honest trade.

- Skills in demand and where to learn them
- Building a portfolio with no clients
- Finding your first clients and setting prices
- Proposals, contracts and payment
- Scams to avoid and a 30-day plan

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